

C64 Visual Assembler — User Manual

Version 1.5.0

A visual, block-based 6502 assembler for the Commodore 64. Build programs by dragging and dropping instruction blocks, and see the generated assembly and machine code in real time.

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1. Interface Overview

The app is split into three main panels:

Panel	Description
Left — Palette	All available instruction and macro blocks. Search or browse by category.
Center — Program	Your program. Drag blocks here, reorder them, edit operands.
Right — Output	Live ASM view and/or memory monitor output.

2. Block Palette

The palette on the left lists all available blocks grouped by category:

- **Data movement** — LDA, LDX, STA, STX, ...
- **Arithmetic** — ADC, SBC, INC, DEC, CMP, ...
- **Logic** — AND, ORA, EOR, BIT
- **Jumps & Branches** — JMP, JSR, RTS, BNE, BEQ, ...
- **Register operations** — TAX, TAY, INX, DEX, ...
- **Shift & Rotate** — ASL, LSR, ROL, ROR
- **Stack** — PHA, PHP, PLA, PLP
- **System** — CLC, SEC, NOP, BRK, ...
- **Illegal instructions** — LAX, SAX, DCP, ...
- **Structure** — LABEL, COMMENT, REGION, ENDREGION
- **Macros** — LOOP, NEXT, PUSH, PULL, TEXT, BYTE, WORD, FILL, ALIGN, STRING, DATA, RAWBYTES, RAWTEXT, PETSCII, INCBIN, SID, INCLUDE, TABLE, ORG, MACRO, ENDM, INVOKE, IF, ELSE, ENDIF, SPRITE_INIT, SPRITE_POS, WAIT_RASTER, JOYSTICK, SPRITE_COL

Use the **search box** at the top of the palette to filter by name. Click the **Add selected block** button or drag a block into the program area.

3. Program Area

- **Drag & drop** blocks from the palette, or **reorder** existing blocks by dragging their handle (≡).
- Each block shows its **mnemonic**, **operand field**, and **addressing mode selector** (where applicable).
- Click the ▶ / ▼ toggle to collapse or expand a block.
- Use the × (**delete**) button on a block to remove it.
- **Collapse All** button folds all blocks at once.

Operand input

- For branch/jump instructions (**BNE**, **JMP**, **JSR**, etc.) a **label picker** dropdown appears — click a defined label to insert it.
- Number format follows the **HEX / DEC** toggle in the toolbar (see section 5).

4. ASM View

The right panel shows the generated output in real time.

Output modes

Mode	Description
ASM	6502 assembly source with addresses and labels
Monitor	Hex / byte dump (C64 monitor style)
Both	ASM on top, monitor below
Options	Program settings panel — number format, macro source toggle, debugger params

Options tab

The **Options** tab contains the settings that affect code generation and output display:

- **Macro source** — when ON, macro definition blocks (MACRO...ENDM) show their source code inline in the ASM view.
- **Program start address** — now set via an **ORG block** in the program area rather than a separate input field. The first ORG block defines the program's load address; subsequent ORG blocks start additional sections at different addresses.
- **Debugger params** — three inline toggles controlling which flags are passed to the external debugger on launch:
 - **-jmp ON/OFF** — jump directly to the program's start address after loading.
 - **-unpause ON/OFF** — unpause the debugger immediately on load.
 - **-wait ms ON/OFF** — adds a **-wait <ms>** delay before unpausing; select 500 ms or 1000 ms from the dropdown.
- **Compile info** — shows a summary of the compiled program (code start address, size, BASIC SYS stub status).

Clicking an ASM line

Click any line in the ASM view to **highlight the corresponding block** in the program area.

ASM line numbers

The ASM panel displays **line numbers** (**001** |, **002** |, ...) to make troubleshooting easier when a compile error points to a specific line.

- The visual line numbers are for diagnostics only.

- **Copy ASM** still copies the clean source text **without** line-number prefixes.

Compile progress modal

During heavier actions, a centered progress modal appears with a progress bar:

- **Run in VICE** — compiling/building PRG and launching emulator.
- **Debug** — compiling/building PRG and launching debugger.
- **Import ASM** — parsing and materializing blocks from pasted source.

The modal closes automatically when the action completes or fails.

5. Settings & Toolbar

Control	Description
Number base (HEX / DEC / BIN)	Sets the display/input format for operands throughout the UI. BIN mode displays values as binary with % prefix (e.g. %11111000). The ASM view always shows each block in its own format.
Language	Switch between English and Hungarian
Theme	Light / Dark / OLED — select from the theme picker in the Settings menu. OLED uses a pure-black background for AMOLED displays.
CRT retro mode	Toggles a full-screen CRT filter: scanlines, phosphor vignette, flicker, and barrel distortion. State is saved between sessions.
BASIC SYS stub	Prepends a BASIC line that calls SYS to your program's origin
Sample	Load a built-in example program
Zoom in / out	Scale the block UI (affects all block elements)
Save Project	Save the current program as a .json project file
Load Project	Load a previously saved project
Import ASM	Opens a paste dialog and imports textual 6502 ASM into blocks
Save PRG	Export the compiled binary as a .prg file
Run (split button)	The main ► Run button runs the current mode; click the ▼ arrow to switch between: Run as PRG (compile and launch VICE directly), Run via D64 (package into a .d64 disk image and launch VICE), or Run on hardware (send PRG to a C64 Ultimate / 1541 Ultimate device). See Section 12 and Section 13 .
Debug (RetroDebugger)	Compile and launch in RetroDebugger with breakpoints, symbols, and autostart flags (see Section 9)
Hardware Settings	Open the hardware configuration dialog — configure VICE, RetroDebugger, and C64 Ultimate (host, password, connection test). See Section 13 .

Control	Description
Debug (C64 Debugger)	Compile and launch in C64 Debugger with the same breakpoints and symbols support (see Section 9)
Clear program	Remove all blocks from the program area
Collapse All	Collapse all blocks
About	Version info
What's New	Changelog
Knowledge Base	Reference links (6502 opcodes, C64 KERNAL, memory map, colors)
Check for Update	Open the itch.io page to check for a newer release

Import ASM (quick reference)

The Import dialog accepts common 6502 source patterns and converts them into blocks:

- `* = $1500` → ORG block
- `Label:` → LABEL block
- `Label: .byte 0` → LABEL + BYTE blocks
- `.byte ...` → BYTE block
- `; comment` (or inline `; ...`) → COMMENT block
- instructions (`lda`, `jsr`, `beq`, etc.) → instruction blocks with detected addressing mode

Import parsing notes and best practices

- Local labels like `.wait` are imported as standard labels (dot removed), and references are normalized accordingly.
- For `($zp),Y` / `($zp,X)` style addressing, use a concrete zero-page byte (`$FB`, `$FC`, etc.) for best compatibility.
- Avoid ambiguous short labels that look like hex (`cc1`, `dead`, `beef`) in branch contexts; prefer names like `loop_cc1`.
- If your program starts with data (`.byte`) before executable code, add an explicit entry jump (for example `JMP Start`) at the top.

6. Addressing Modes

Each 6502 instruction supports one or more addressing modes. The mode selector appears on each block.

Mode	Label	Example	Description
implied	Implied	<code>NOP</code>	No operand; the instruction is self-contained
immediate	Immediate	<code>LDA #\$FF</code>	Inline constant; the assembler adds <code>#</code> automatically
zeroPage	Zero page	<code>LDA \$10</code>	Single byte address in page zero (0–255)

Mode	Label	Example	Description
zeroPageX	Zero page,X	LDA \$10,X	Zero page address + X register offset (result wraps in page 0)
zeroPageY	Zero page,Y	LDX \$FB,Y	Zero page address + Y register offset
absolute	Absolute	LDA \$0400	Full 16-bit memory address
absoluteX	Absolute,X	LDA \$0400,X	16-bit address + X register offset
absoluteY	Absolute,Y	LDA \$0400,Y	16-bit address + Y register offset
relative	Relative/Label	BNE loop	For branch instructions; enter a label name or target address
indirectX	Indirect,X	LDA (\$FB,X)	Zero page indexed indirect (operand = zero page address, 1 byte)
indirectY	Indirect,Y	LDA (\$FB),Y	Zero page indirect indexed (operand = zero page address, 1 byte)
indirect	Indirect	JMP (\$0100)	Indirect; only usable with JMP

Label expressions as operands

Any operand field that accepts an address or immediate value also accepts a **constant name** (from a **CONST** block or a **LABEL**) directly. Additionally, you can use **label+offset** or **label-offset** expressions to reference an address relative to a named constant:

Syntax	Example	Description
label	STA screen_ram,X	Resolves to the label/constant value
label+\$hex	STA screen_ram+\$0100,X	Label address plus a hex offset
label+decimal	STA screen_ram+256,X	Label address plus a decimal offset
label-\$hex	LDA table-\$10	Label address minus a hex offset
#<label	LDA #<screen_ram	Low byte of the label address
#>label	LDA #>screen_ram	High byte of the label address

Example — clear two screen pages using a CONST:

```
; .CONST screen_ram = $0400
    LDX #$00
clear:
    STA screen_ram,X
    STA screen_ram+$0100,X
```

DEX
BNE clear

7. Standard 6502 Instructions

Data Movement

Mnemonic	Description	Modes
LDA	Load Accumulator	immediate, zeroPage, absolute, absoluteX, absoluteY, indirectX, indirectY
LDX	Load X register	immediate, zeroPage, zeroPageY, absolute, absoluteY
LDY	Load Y register	immediate, zeroPage, absolute, absoluteX
STA	Store Accumulator	zeroPage, absolute, absoluteX, absoluteY, indirectX, indirectY
STX	Store X register	zeroPage, zeroPageY, absolute
STY	Store Y register	zeroPage, absolute

Arithmetic

Mnemonic	Description	Notes
ADC	Add with carry	Set carry with SEC before use in most cases
SBC	Subtract with carry	Set carry with SEC before subtraction
INC	Increment memory	—
DEC	Decrement memory	—
CMP	Compare with A	Sets flags; does not modify A
CPX	Compare with X	—
CPY	Compare with Y	—

Logic

Mnemonic	Description
AND	Logical AND with Accumulator
ORA	Logical OR with Accumulator
EOR	Exclusive OR with Accumulator
BIT	Test bits in memory against A (sets N, V, Z flags)

Jumps & Branches

Mnemonic	Description
JMP	Unconditional jump (absolute or indirect)
JSR	Jump to subroutine (saves return address on stack)
RTS	Return from subroutine
RTI	Return from interrupt
BNE	Branch if Not Equal (Z=0)
BEQ	Branch if Equal (Z=1)
BCC	Branch if Carry Clear (C=0)
BCS	Branch if Carry Set (C=1)
BMI	Branch if Minus (N=1)
BPL	Branch if Plus (N=0)
BVC	Branch if Overflow Clear (V=0)
BVS	Branch if Overflow Set (V=1)

Register Operations

Mnemonic	Description
TAX	Transfer A → X
TAY	Transfer A → Y
TXA	Transfer X → A
TYA	Transfer Y → A
TSX	Transfer Stack pointer → X
TXS	Transfer X → Stack pointer
INX	Increment X
DEX	Decrement X
INY	Increment Y
DEY	Decrement Y

Shift & Rotate

Mnemonic	Description
ASL	Arithmetic Shift Left
LSR	Logical Shift Right

Mnemonic	Description
ROL	Rotate Left through Carry
ROR	Rotate Right through Carry

Stack

Mnemonic	Description
PHA	Push Accumulator onto stack
PHP	Push Processor status onto stack
PLA	Pull Accumulator from stack
PLP	Pull Processor status from stack

System / Flags

Mnemonic	Description
CLC	Clear Carry flag
CLD	Clear Decimal mode
CLI	Clear Interrupt disable
CLV	Clear Overflow flag
SEC	Set Carry flag
SED	Set Decimal mode
SEI	Set Interrupt disable
NOP	No operation
BRK	Force break / software interrupt

Illegal / Undocumented Instructions

These are supported for advanced use. Use with care — behavior may differ between chips.

LAX, SAX, DCP, ISC, SLO, RLA, SRE, RRA, ANC, ALR, ARR, AXS

8. Macro Blocks — Reference

Macro blocks generate multiple instructions or data directives automatically. They are found in the **Macros** category of the palette.

LABEL

Creates a named label that can be used as a jump target.

Field	Description
Label name	Identifier used in JMP , JSR , BNE , etc.

Generated ASM:

```
loop:    ; $0820
```

The address is shown as a comment. Labels have **0 byte size**.

COMMENT

Inserts a comment line in the ASM output. No bytes generated.

Generated ASM:

```
; Your comment text here
```

BYTE

Inserts an arbitrary sequence of raw bytes.

Field	Description
Operand	Comma-separated byte values (e.g. \$01 , \$02 , \$FF or 1 , 2 , 255)

Generated ASM:

```
.byte $01, $02, $FF
```

Size: Number of bytes in the list.

WORD

Inserts 16-bit values stored as little-endian LO/Hi byte pairs.

Field	Description
Operand	Comma-separated 16-bit values (e.g. \$0400 , \$C000)

Generated ASM:

```
.word $0400, $C000
```

Size: 2 bytes per word.

FILL

Generates a repeated sequence of the same byte value.

Field	Description
Operand	<code>count,value</code> — e.g. <code>256,0</code> fills 256 bytes with zero

Generated ASM:

```
.fill 256, $00
```

Size: The count value in bytes.

ALIGN

Advances the program counter to the next boundary of the given size. Inserts padding bytes as needed.

Field	Description
Boundary	Alignment value — e.g. <code>64</code> (sprite boundary), <code>256</code> (page), <code>\$2000</code> (bitmap)

Generated ASM:

```
; ALIGN 64 → $0840 (12 bytes padding)
```

Size: Dynamic — depends on the current program counter position.

Tip: Use `ALIGN 64` before sprite data, `ALIGN 256` to ensure page-aligned tables.

TEXT

Writes a text string to the C64 screen RAM at a given row/column position using the KERNAL CHROUT routine.

Field	Description
Text	The string to display
X	Column (0–39)

Field	Description
Y	Row (0–24)

Generated ASM:

```
LDA #$48      ; 'H'
JSR $FFD2
LDA #$45      ; 'E'
JSR $FFD2
...
```

Characters are encoded as PETSCII. **Size:** `text.length` × 5 bytes (LDA + JSR per character).

STRING

Places a PETSCII-encoded string as raw bytes at a given memory address (no runtime code, deferred data section).

Field	Description
Text	The string to place
Address	Target memory address (e.g. <code>\$C000</code>)

Generated ASM:

```
.byte $48, $45, $4C, $4C, $4F ; "HELLO"
```

Placed at the specified address. **Size:** `text.length` bytes.

DATA

Writes raw bytes to a given memory address using LDA/STA instructions at runtime.

Field	Description
Bytes	Comma-separated byte values
Address	Target memory address

Generated ASM:

```
LDA #$01
STA $C000
LDA #$02
```

```
STA $C001
```

```
...
```

Size: `byte_count` × 5 bytes (one LDA + one STA per byte).

RAWBYTES

Places raw bytes at a given memory address — no runtime code is generated. The bytes appear in the deferred data section of the output.

Field	Description
Bytes	Comma-separated byte values
Address	Target memory address (e.g. <code>\$C000</code>)

Size in code: 0 bytes. The data is placed at the given address in the output.

Use this instead of DATA when you don't need runtime initialization code and just want bytes at an address.

RAWTEXT

Like RAWBYTES but accepts a text string that is encoded as PETSCII bytes.

Field	Description
Text	String to encode
Address	Target memory address

Size in code: 0 bytes.

PETSCII

Places a text string encoded as PETSCII bytes at a given memory address. No runtime code is generated — the bytes are placed directly at the target address, similar to RAWBYTES.

Each printable ASCII character (codes 32–126) is stored using its standard ASCII value, which corresponds to the PETSCII uppercase range. The result is compatible with KERNAL CHROUT (`$FFD2`).

Field	Description
Text	String to encode as PETSCII bytes
Address	Target memory address (e.g. <code>\$C000</code>)

Generated ASM:

```
; .petscii "HELLO" -> $C000
; $C000
    .byte $48, $45, $4C, $4C, $4F    ; H E L L O
```

Size in code: 0 bytes. The data is placed at the target address as a deferred data section (like RAWBYTES).

Encoding rules:

Input	Byte value
Printable ASCII (space, letters, digits, punctuation)	Standard ASCII code (32–126)
Newline	\$0D (RETURN)
Everything else	\$20 (space)

Tip: Use PETSCII for data that will be output via CHROUT (\$FFD2). For screen-code strings (different mapping), use the STRING macro instead.

INCBIN

Includes an external binary file and places its content at a given memory address.

Field	Description
File	Browse to select a .bin , .prg , .sid , or .raw file
Address	Target load address (e.g. \$C000)

Generated ASM comment:

```
; INCBIN "music.bin" @ $C000 (2048 bytes)
.byte $01, $02, ...
```

Size in code: 0 bytes (deferred data section). The binary is embedded at the given address.

SID

Loads a SID music file and embeds its raw data directly into the assembled PRG at a configurable memory address. Header metadata (Load/Init/Play addresses, title, author) is extracted automatically.

Field	Description
File	Browse to select a .sid file
Custom address (optional)	Override the SID's native load address (e.g. \$1000). Leave empty to use the address from the SID header.

The block displays:

- **Title / Author** from the SID header
- **Load address** — where the data is placed in memory (effective address after any override)
- **Init address** — call this with JSR to initialize the music (adjusted for relocation if a custom address is used)
- **Play address** — call this with JSR on every frame in an IRQ handler (adjusted for relocation)
- A **(relocated)** badge appears when a custom address shifts the data from its original position

Generated ASM comment:

```
    ; SID "Ikari_Warriors.sid" @ $1000  Init:$1000  Play:$1006  (4096 bytes)
```

Size in code: 0 bytes inline. The SID binary is placed at the specified address as a deferred chunk in the PRG.

Important: Most SID files contain hardcoded internal absolute addresses. They can only be relocated if the entire binary is shifted by the same offset. If a SID has internal jumps to **\$10xx**, it must remain at **\$1000** — moving it to a different address will break those internal references.

Typical usage: Place an ORG block before the SID block to set its address. Call Init once at startup, then call Play every frame from a raster IRQ handler.

INCLUDE

Includes another Visual Assembler project file and expands its blocks inline at this position. The included blocks are read-only.

Field	Description
File	Browse to select a .json Visual Assembler project
Load address (optional)	If set (hex, e.g. C000), the included blocks are placed at that address — a synthetic ORG is injected before them, overriding any ORG block inside the included file. Leave empty to let the included file's own ORG blocks control placement.

Generated ASM (no address override):

```
    ; .include "library.json" - 12 block(s)
    ... (expanded blocks follow)
```

Generated ASM (with load address **C000):**

```
    ; .include "library.json" @ $C000 - 12 block(s)
    *=$C000
    ... (expanded blocks follow)
```

Tip: Use INCLUDE to build reusable subroutine libraries that you can share across projects. Set a load address when the library has no ORG of its own, or when you want to override its default placement.

TABLE

Defines a lookup table at a fixed memory address with a named label.

Field	Description
Name	Label identifier for the table (e.g. <code>color_table</code>)
Address	Fixed address where the table starts (e.g. <code>\$C000</code>)

Generated ASM:

```
color_table:
```

The program counter jumps to the specified address for subsequent blocks. Place BYTE/WORD/FILL blocks after TABLE to fill the table content.

Size: 0 bytes.

ORG

Sets a new **program counter origin** — equivalent to the `* = $ADDR` assembler directive. The first ORG block in your program defines its primary load address. Use additional ORG blocks to split the program into multiple sections that load at different addresses.

Field	Description
Address	The new origin address (e.g. <code>0801</code> in HEX, or <code>2049</code> in DEC)
HEX / DEC	Toggle the address input between hexadecimal and decimal display

Generated ASM:

```
* = $C000
```

Size: 0 bytes. The ORG block itself generates no machine code.

Each ORG block starts a new code section. All blocks following an ORG (until the next ORG or end of program) are assembled relative to that address. When the PRG is exported, all sections are merged into a single flat buffer: the load address is the lowest section start across all sections; gaps between sections are zero-filled.

Example — code at `$0801`, data table at `$C000`:


```

* = $0801
    LDX #$00
loop:
    LDA $C000,X
    STA $D800,X
    INX
    BNE loop
    RTS

* = $C000
    .byte $01, $02, $03, ...

```

Tip: Every program must start with an **ORG** block. The typical starting address for a C64 BASIC-loadable program is **\$0801** (2049 decimal). When **BASIC SYS stub** is enabled, the assembler adds a short BASIC line at **\$0801** and your code starts at **\$080D**.

LOOP / NEXT

A counted loop pair using a register as the counter.

LOOP

Field	Description
Register	X or Y — the counter register
Count	Loop iteration count (hex or decimal, e.g. 0A = 10)
Label	Auto-generated loop label (e.g. loop0)

Generated ASM:

```

    LDX #$0A
loop0:

```

Size: 2 bytes (LD_ opcode + immediate operand).

NEXT

Field	Description
Register	Automatically matched to the LOOP register
Label	Automatically linked to the LOOP label

Generated ASM:

```
DEX
BNE loop0
```

Size: 3 bytes (DEX + BNE + branch offset).

Example — clear 10 screen cells:

```
LDX #$0A
loop0:
LDA #$20      ; space character
STA $0400,X
DEX
BNE loop0
```

PUSH / PULL

Save and restore registers using the stack.

PUSH

Pushes one or more registers onto the stack. The order is always $A \rightarrow X \rightarrow Y$ (innermost first).

Field	Description
Registers	Any combination: A , X , Y , AX , AY , XY , AXY

Generated ASM (example: **AX):**

```
PHA
TXA
PHA
```

Size: 1 byte for A (**PHA**), 2 bytes for X or Y (transfer + push).

PULL

Restores registers from the stack in reverse order ($Y \rightarrow X \rightarrow A$).

Field	Description
Registers	Same as PUSH — must match the corresponding PUSH block

Generated ASM (example: **AX):**

PLA
TAX
PLA

Important: Always pair PUSH and PULL with the same register set, and in reverse order. **PUSH AX** must be matched by **PULL AX** (which internally does Y-first, then X, then A).

MACRO / ENDM / INVOKE

Define and reuse your own named code blocks.

MACRO (definition start)

Field	Description
Name	Identifier for the macro (e.g. clear_screen)

Marks the beginning of a macro definition. All blocks between MACRO and ENDM become the macro body. The definition does **not** generate code where it appears.

Generated ASM:

```
; .MACRO clear_screen
... (body blocks)
; .ENDM
```

ENDM (definition end)

Closes the current macro definition. No fields.

INVOKE

Inserts the contents of a named macro at this position.

Field	Description
Macro name	Select from the dropdown of defined macros

Generated ASM:

```
; >>> Invoke: clear_screen
... (expanded macro body)
```

The macro body is expanded inline — all addresses and labels are resolved in context.

Tip: Define macros at the top (or bottom) of your program, then INVOKE them wherever needed. Macros can be invoked multiple times.

REGION / ENDREGION

Groups a set of blocks into a **named, collapsible section**. REGION and ENDREGION are purely visual — they generate **zero bytes** and have no effect on the assembled output.

Field	Description
Region name	Free-text label for the section (e.g. <code>init</code> , <code>game_loop</code> , <code>sprite_setup</code>)

Controls on the REGION block:

- ▶ / ▼ **toggle** — collapses or expands the entire region. When collapsed, all blocks between REGION and ENDREGION are hidden and the REGION block's own body folds in.
- ☒ **Expand all** — un-collapses every individually collapsed block inside the region and expands the region itself if needed.
- ⊖ **Select in ASM** — highlights the entire region's code range in the ASM view (from `; ===[ name ]===` to `; ===[/name]===`) and scrolls to it. Switches to the ASM tab automatically if it is not currently visible.

Generated ASM:

```
; region init
    SEI
    LDA #$00
    STA $D020
; endregion init
```

Size: 0 bytes for both REGION and ENDREGION.

Example workflow:

1. Add a **REGION** block, set region name to `init`.
2. Add your initialization instructions below it.
3. Add an **ENDREGION** block to close the section.
4. Click ▶ on the REGION to collapse the whole section into one line while working on other parts of the program.

Note: Regions **can be nested** — a REGION placed inside another region acts as a child group (syntax sugar for visual organisation). Each ENDREGION closes the nearest preceding unclosed REGION. Nesting has no effect on the assembled output.

DEFINE / IF / ELSE / ENDIF

Conditional assembly blocks. Add a **DEFINE** block to activate a named symbol — any **IF** block whose condition matches a **DEFINE** present in the program is assembled; its **ELSE** branch (if any) is skipped, and vice

versa.

DEFINE

Field	Description
Symbol	One or more comma-separated identifiers to activate (e.g. <code>DEBUG</code> or <code>DEBUG, PAL</code>)

Generated ASM:

```
; .DEFINE DEBUG
; .DEFINE DEBUG, PAL
```

A single `DEFINE` block can activate multiple symbols at once using a comma-separated list. Place `DEFINE` blocks anywhere in the program (typically at the top). Removing the block deactivates all its symbols instantly.

IF

Field	Description
Condition	Identifier to test (must match a <code>DEFINE</code> symbol to be active)

Generated ASM:

```
; .IF DEBUG
```

Blocks between `IF` and `ENDIF` (or `ELSE`) are included or skipped based on whether the condition symbol has a matching `DEFINE` block in the program. Skipped blocks appear as `; [IF skipped] ...` comments and generate **zero bytes**.

ELSE

No fields. Marks the alternative branch — assembled when the `IF` condition is *not* active.

Generated ASM:

```
; .ELSE
```

ENDIF

No fields. Closes the conditional block.

Generated ASM:

```
; .ENDIF
```

Size: 0 bytes for all four blocks. Only the content *between* them counts.

Example — debug border flash, release build skips it:

```
; .DEFINE DEBUG

; .IF DEBUG
    LDA #$02      ; red border
    STA $D020
; .ELSE
    LDA #$00      ; black (release)
    STA $D020
; .ENDIF
```

Example — multiple symbols in one DEFINE block:

```
; .DEFINE DEBUG, PAL

; .IF PAL
    LDA #$xx      ; PAL timing constant
; .ELSE
    LDA #$xx      ; NTSC timing constant
; .ENDIF
```

Nested **IF** blocks are supported. The innermost condition is evaluated independently; an outer skipped block causes all inner blocks to be skipped regardless of their condition.

CONST

Declares a named constant. The constant is added to the label table and can be referenced as an operand in any instruction block (LDA, STA, JSR, JMP, etc.).

Field	Description
Name	Identifier for the constant (e.g. SCREEN)
Value	Numeric value in the selected base (e.g. 0400 in HEX = address \$0400)
Format	HEX or DEC — controls how the value is entered and displayed

Generated ASM:

```
; .CONST SCREEN = $0400
```

The constant name appears in the **label picker** dropdown of instruction blocks that support absolute/immediate addressing — simply click it to insert the constant name as the operand.

Size: 0 bytes.

SPRITE_INIT

Initialises a VIC-II sprite in a single block: sets the **data pointer**, **enable bit**, and **colour**.

Field	Description
Sprite #	Sprite number 0–7
Colour	Colour index 0–15 (C64 palette)
Data page	Sprite data address / 64 (e.g. \$21 if data is at \$0840)

Generated ASM:

```
LDA #$21
STA $07F8      ; sprite pointer register ($07F8 + N)
LDA $D015
ORA #$01      ; set enable bit for sprite 0
STA $D015
LDA #$07
STA $D027      ; sprite 0 colour register
```

Size: 18 bytes.

Sprite data page: data_address / 64. With the default BASIC SYS stub, an ALIGN 64 block after JMP main places sprite data at \$0840 → page = \$0840 / 64 = 33 = \$21.

SPRITE_POS

Sets a sprite's **static start position** (compile-time constant). Use this for initial placement; for animation use INC/DEC on the sprite's register directly.

Field	Description
Sprite #	Sprite number 0–7
X	Horizontal position 0–319
Y	Vertical position 0–255

Generated ASM (example: sprite 0, X=152, Y=100):

```

LDA #$98      ; X low byte
STA $D000     ; sprite 0 X register
LDA $D010
AND #$FE      ; clear X MSB for sprite 0 ( $X \leq 255$ )
STA $D010
LDA #$64      ; Y = 100
STA $D001     ; sprite 0 Y register

```

For $X > 255$ the macro sets the corresponding bit in `$D010` instead of clearing it.

Size: 18 bytes.

Note: `SPRITE_POS` bakes the position into the code at assemble time (`LDA #$xx`). To move a sprite at runtime use `INC $D000` / `DEC $D000` directly — see the `sprite-macro-demo` sample.

WAIT_RASTER

Waits for a specific VIC-II raster line — entirely **inline**, no JSR and no external label required.

Field	Description
Raster line	Target raster line in hex (e.g. <code>FF</code> = line 255)

Generated ASM:

```

wait:
    LDA $D012      ; current raster line
    CMP #$FF       ; target line
    BNE wait       ; loop back (-7 bytes)

```

Size: 7 bytes (the `BNE` offset `$F9` = -7 always points back to the `LDA`).

Tip: Place `WAIT_RASTER` at the top of your game loop to synchronise with the display and prevent sprite tearing.

JOYSTICK

Reads a CIA joystick port and moves a sprite according to the direction pressed. Entirely **inline** — no JSR or label needed.

Field	Description
Port	<code>1</code> = port 1 (<code>\$DC01</code>) or <code>2</code> = port 2 (<code>\$DC00</code>)
Sprite #	Sprite number 0–7 (controls which X/Y register pair is updated)

Generated ASM (port 2, sprite 0):


```

    LDA $DC00      ; read CIA port 2
    LSR            ; bit 0 → carry (Up)
    BCS skip_up    ; carry set = NOT pressed
    DEC $D001      ; Y-1 (move up)
skip_up:
    LSR            ; bit 1 → carry (Down)
    BCS skip_down
    INC $D001      ; Y+1 (move down)
skip_down:
    LSR            ; bit 2 → carry (Left)
    BCS skip_left
    DEC $D000      ; X-1 (move left)
skip_left:
    LSR            ; bit 3 → carry (Right)
    BCS skip_right
    INC $D000      ; X+1 (move right)
skip_right:

```

Joystick bit map (active-LOW — bit = 0 means pressed):

Bit	Direction	CIA register
0	Up	\$DC00 (port 2) / \$DC01 (port 1)
1	Down	
2	Left	
3	Right	
4	Fire	(not handled by this macro)

Size: 27 bytes. The **BCS** offset is always **+3** (skips the following 3-byte **DEC/INC abs** instruction).

Typical usage: Place inside a **gameloop** label with **WAIT_RASTER** first:

```

gameloop:
    WAIT_RASTER ($FF)
    JOYSTICK (port=2, sprite=0)
    JMP gameloop

```

SPRITE_COL

Detects sprite collisions using the VIC-II hardware collision registers. Entirely **inline** — no JSR or label needed.

Field	Description
Sprite #	Sprite number 0–7 (which sprite's bit to check)

Field	Description
Collision type	Sprite-Sprite (\$D01E) — collision with another sprite; Sprite-Background (\$D01F) — collision with background graphics

Generated ASM (sprite 0, sprite–sprite):

```

LDA $D01E      ; read sprite-sprite collision register (clears it!)
AND #$01       ; isolate bit 0 (sprite 0)
                ; A ≠ 0 → collision occurred

```

Size: 5 bytes.

Important: Reading \$D01E / \$D01F **automatically clears the register**. Always read it exactly once per frame — use the result immediately with BEQ/BNE.

Typical usage:

```

gameloop:
    WAIT_RASTER ($FF)
    JOYSTICK (port=2, sprite=0)
    SPRITE_COL (sprite=0, type=sprite-sprite)
    BEQ no_hit      ; A = 0 → no collision
    LDA #$02
    STA $D020       ; red border = hit!
    JMP gameloop
no_hit:
    LDA #$0E
    STA $D020       ; light blue border = clear
    JMP gameloop

```

See also: collision-demo sample — green ball (sprite #0) vs. red cross (sprite #1).

LOADFILE

Loads a file from a D64 disk at runtime using the C64 KERNAL routines SETNAM (\$FFBD), SETLFS (\$FFBA), and LOAD (\$FFD5). Use this macro to load data, music, or additional code from disk while your program is running.

Field	Description
Filename	File name on the disk (max 16 chars, auto-uppercase; characters , , " , / , \ , : , * , ? , < , > , are filtered)
Device	Device number 8–30 (default 8)
Override address (optional)	Hex load address (e.g. C000). If set, the file is loaded to this address (sec=0, ignoring the PRG header). Leave empty to use the file's own 2-byte PRG header (sec=1).

Field	Description
Error label (optional)	If set, a BCS instruction is generated after JSR LOAD. If the KERNAL returns with carry set (error), execution jumps to this label.

Generated code structure:

```

    JMP skip_filename      ; jump over the inline filename
    .byte "DEMO-COLORS"   ; filename bytes (PETSCII, 11 chars)
skip_filename:
    LDA #11               ; filename length
    LDX #<fname            ; pointer lo
    LDY #>fname            ; pointer hi
    JSR $FFBD             ; SETNAM
    LDA #1                 ; logical file #1
    LDX #8                 ; device 8
    LDY #0                 ; sec=0 (override addr) or #1 (file's own addr)
    JSR $FFBA             ; SETLFS
    LDA #0                 ; LOAD command (not VERIFY)
    JSR $FFD5             ; LOAD
    BCS fail              ; (only if error label set)

```

Size: 3 + filename_length + 9 (SETNAM) + 9 (SETLFS) + (4 if override) + 5 (LOAD) + (2 if error label) bytes. Minimum 27 bytes.

Important: The filename is stored inline in the machine code right after a **JMP skip_filename**. The file name on the disk must be uppercase PETSCII — which matches plain ASCII uppercase letters (A–Z). The macro enforces this automatically.

Error handling: The KERNAL sets the carry flag if LOAD fails (no drive, file not found, etc.). Without an error label, a failure leaves carry set and execution falls through to whatever follows — which is almost certainly wrong. Always provide an error label for production programs.

See also: [loadfile-demo](#) sample — demonstrates loading **DEMO-COLORS.PRG** from a D64 with a BCS error branch and a visual error screen.

9. Debugger Integration

The app supports two external C64 debuggers: **RetroDebugger** and **C64 Debugger**. Both receive breakpoints, symbols, and autostart flags generated from the assembled program.

RetroDebugger

[RetroDebugger](#) is a cross-platform Commodore 64 debugger with breakpoint support, memory inspection, and label-aware disassembly.

Setup: Open **Settings** → **Configure RetroDebugger executable** and point it to the [RetroDebugger](#) binary.

Launch: Click **Debug (RetroDebugger)** in the toolbar. The app will:

1. Assemble the program to a `.prg` file in a temporary directory.
2. Write a **breakpoints file** (`breakpoints.txt`) — one `break $ADDR` per flagged block.
3. Write a **symbols file** (`symbols.txt`) in Vice/RetroDebugger label format (`al C:addr .name`). All LABEL and CONST blocks are included.
4. Launch RetroDebugger with:

```
RetroDebugger -prg <file.prg> -breakpoints <breakpoints.txt> -symbols
<symbols.txt> [flags]
```

C64 Debugger

[C64 Debugger](#) is another popular Commodore 64 debugger and emulator.

Setup: Open **Settings** → **Configure C64 Debugger executable** and point it to the `c64debugger` binary.

Launch: Click **Debug (C64 Debugger)** in the toolbar. The same `.prg`, breakpoints, and symbols files are generated and passed to C64 Debugger with the configured flags.

Breakpoint Blocks

Click the breakpoint icon (●) on any instruction block to toggle it as a breakpoint. Breakpointed blocks are highlighted in red. Their addresses are written to the breakpoints file on every debugger launch.

Debugger Flags (Options Tab)

Toggle	Flag	Effect
<code>-jmp ON</code>	<code>-jmp \$ADDR</code>	Jump directly to the program start address after loading
<code>-unpause ON</code>	<code>-unpause</code>	Unpause the debugger immediately on load
<code>-wait ON</code>	<code>-wait <ms></code>	Wait <code><ms></code> milliseconds before unpauseing — 500 ms or 1000 ms

Tip: For most programs, enable `-jmp` and `-unpause` for instant autostart. Use `-wait 500` or `-wait 1000` when your program sets up IRQs or SID music that needs time to initialize before the first raster.

10. Knowledge Base Links

Quick reference links available in the app under **Knowledge Base**:

Resource	URL
6502 Opcodes Reference	http://www.6502.org/tutorials/6502opcodes.html
C64 KERNAL Functions	https://sta.c64.org/cbm64krnfunc.html
C64 Memory Map	https://sta.c64.org/cbm64mem.html
C64 Color Codes	https://sta.c64.org/cbm64col.html

Resource	URL
VIC-II Article	https://www.cebix.net/VIC-Article.txt
C64 Codebase	https://codebase.c64.org/
The Turbo Assembler	https://turbo.style64.org/
RetroDebugger	https://github.com/slajerek/RetroDebugger/

11. ASM Import Workflow

The Import ASM dialog now includes quality-of-life safeguards for iterative fixes:

- **Line numbers in the import editor** are synchronized with scroll position.
- **Inline error list** is shown at the bottom of the same dialog when import fails.
- **Source preservation on failure** restores your pasted source automatically, so you can correct and retry without re-pasting.

This keeps the import-debug cycle inside one dialog: paste, import, inspect errors, fix, retry.

12. D64 Export & Run

Version 1.5.0 adds the ability to package your program (and additional data files) into a C64 D64 disk image and launch it in VICE — or export the disk image for use elsewhere.

Split Run button

The toolbar **Run** button has been replaced by a **split button**:

Part	Action
► Run (main)	Executes the currently selected run mode
▼ (arrow)	Opens the mode selector

Available run modes:

Mode	Description
Run as PRG	Assemble to a temporary .prg and launch VICE directly. Classic behaviour.
Run via D64	Assemble, build a .d64 disk image (using c1541), add any configured extra files, then launch VICE from the disk. Use this whenever your program loads files at runtime (e.g. with the LOADFILE macro).
Run on hardware	Assemble to PRG and send it to a 1541 Ultimate / Ultimate 64 device over the local network. See Section 13 .

The selected mode is saved between sessions.

Export to D64 dialog

Open via the **Save PRG ▾** dropdown → **Export to D64**. The dialog lets you:

1. Set the **disk name** (max 16 chars) and **program name** — these are the names that appear in the C64 disk directory.
2. **Add extra files** — click + to pick any binary file (**.prg**, **.bin**, **.sid**, etc.). For each extra:
 - **Name** — how it appears in the D64 directory (max 16 chars, auto-uppercase).
 - **Load address (optional)** — if provided, a 2-byte PRG header is prepended. Leave empty to write raw bytes with no header.
3. Click **Export** to generate the **.d64** file using VICE's **c1541** tool.

D64 metadata in projects

The disk name, program name, and extra file list are saved inside the project JSON (under the **d64** key). When you reload the project or a sample that includes D64 metadata, the extras are restored automatically — no need to re-add them each time.

The **loadfile-demo** sample comes pre-configured with **DEMO-COLORS.PRG** as an extra file. Select it, open **Run via D64**, and click **Run** to see the full load flow in action.

Requirement: D64 export and Run via D64 both require VICE (**c1541**) to be configured in [Hardware Settings](#).

13. Hardware Settings

Open via **Settings → Hardware Settings...** in the toolbar menu. All external hardware paths and network configuration live here.

VICE Emulator

Setting	Description
Select VICE	Browse to the x64sc (or x64) VICE executable
Status	Shows whether the executable path is valid and accessible

VICE is required for **Run as PRG**, **Run via D64**, and **Export to D64**.

Retro Debugger

Setting	Description
Select RetroDebugger	Browse to the RetroDebugger binary
Status	Shows whether the path is valid

See [Section 9](#) for full debugger documentation.

C64 Ultimate / 1541 Ultimate

Run assembled PRGs directly on real hardware over the local network using the Ultimate REST API.

Setting	Description
Host (IP)	IP address of the device (e.g. <code>192.168.1.100</code>)
Password	Optional — if the device requires authentication
Test connection	Sends a test request to <code>/v3/runners/info</code> ; shows OK or error

Workflow:

1. Connect the 1541 Ultimate / Ultimate 64 to your local network.
2. Enter its IP address (and password if set) in Hardware Settings.
3. Select **Run on hardware** from the split run menu.
4. Click ► **Run** — the PRG is compiled and sent to the device via HTTP POST to `/v3/runners/prg`. The device loads and runs it on the C64 immediately.

Tip: No USB cable or driver needed — the REST API is built into the Ultimate firmware. Your computer and the device must be on the same local network.